

A Colourful Past: The Royal Hotel, Gympie

For over 140 years, the corner of Mary and Monkland Streets has been the beating heart of Gympie's social scene—a place where stories unfold, music drifts through open windows, and generations gather to celebrate, commiserate, and connect. The Royal Hotel, as it stands today is the latest chapter in a long and lively tale that began in 1868. Originally built as the Exchange Hotel and Varieties Theatre, the site quickly became a magnet for entertainment and hospitality. By 1887, it boasted a theatre and dancing room, hosting everything from travelling performers to spirited community dances. The atmosphere was always lively, and the building itself became a symbol of Gympie's booming gold rush era—a place where miners, merchants, and musicians mingled under one roof. Nature, however, had other plans. In 1875, a cyclone tore through the town, destroying part of the theatre. That same year, devastating floods submerged much of Gympie, testing the resilience of its people and its buildings. But the spirit of the Exchange endured. Rebuilt and reopened as the Varieties Hotel and Theatre, it once again drew good crowds, offering a welcome escape and a sense of continuity in uncertain times. In 1885, the establishment was renamed the Royal Hotel, and by 1910, its entertainment wing had evolved into the Theatre Royal. The venue became a cultural cornerstone, hosting plays, concerts, and community events that shaped the town's identity. It was a place where Gympie came to life—where laughter echoed off the walls and applause rang out beneath the chandeliers. Tragedy struck in 1935 when fire razed the building to the ground. But even this could not extinguish the Royal's legacy. In 1938, Bulimba Brewery purchased the site and constructed a new hotel, this time with a striking Art Deco facade that still graces the corner today. Sleek lines, geometric motifs, and bold design choices gave the Royal a fresh identity—one that honoured its past while embracing the future. Over the decades, the Royal Hotel has faced its share of challenges. Floodwaters have swept through its halls more than once, leaving behind mud and memories. Yet each time, the Royal has cleaned up, reopened its doors, and welcomed the community back with open arms. It has become a symbol of Gympie's resilience—a place that bends but never breaks. Following a significant refurbishment in recent years, the Royal now offers comfortable and affordable accommodation, blending heritage charm with modern convenience. While the bar and entertainment areas are no longer open to the public daily, they are available for private bookings by appointment—perfect for functions, conferences, and special gatherings. The Royal remains a place where stories are shared, memories are made, and history lives on.